

Travels into print: authoring, editing and narratives of travel and exploration, c.1815–c.1857

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This paper examines the relationships between authorship and editing in the production of narratives of travel and exploration. The context to the paper is the widespread interest in exploration and travel writing in geography and related fields, and the materialist hermeneutic apparent in the conjunction of geography, book history and the history of science. Through assessment of archival and printed evidence relating to the authorship and editing of books of travel and exploration published by the leading British publisher, John Murray, the paper examines the redactive relationships between writer and editor-publisher, illustrates the means by which authors sought status in their words and explores how Murray authorised explorers' words and works. In addressing the complex connections between author and editor, manuscript and print, private correspondence and public audience, the paper has implications for researchers in geography interested in the specific relationships between writing and print, and in the general connections between geography, book history and the history of science.

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Introduction

The study of written accounts of travel and exploration is a central feature in geography and in other disciplines. Scholars in literary studies have addressed the links between narratives of travel, the making and unmaking of empire, the imperial 'self' and 'other', and literary form (Adams 1962; Batten 1978; Fulford *et al.* 2004; Gilroy 2000; Kuehn and Smethurst 2008; Leask 2002; Pratt 1992; Regard 2009). Social anthropologists and historians of anthropological practice have examined the facts and cultural consequences of narrative, travel and 'travelling theory' in the West's encounter with 'the Rest' (Bravo and Sörlin 2002; Clifford 1997; Said 1984). Book historians have demonstrated the importance of print history as a form of communicative action and the fluidity of meaning associated with the making, transmission and reception of the printed word (Johns 1998; Secord 2000 2004).

Others have scrutinised the disputed truth claims in travellers' words (Stagl 1995). Historians of art have been concerned with the fidelity of visual depiction in illustrated travel accounts (Fraser 2008; Stafford 1984). For historians of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century science especially, narratives of travel and exploration provide key raw material for understanding the development of the modern sciences, and for tracing the circulation and mediation of new global data (Iliffe 2003; Liebersohn 2003; Raj 2007; Schaffer *et al.* 2009).

Many of these issues are apparent in work in geography. In general, geographical studies of the practices and products of travel have either been substantive – concerned, for example, with questions of travel, gender and imperialism in Africa (Blunt 1995) or with the discursive complexities of reading travel accounts in contemporary context (Duncan and Gregory 1999). Or, more commonly, they have been focused and thematic: addressing,

for example, travel and the making of 'the imperial subject' (Kearns 1997); the connections between writing and the act of travel (Gregory 1995; Sharp 2002); the re-appraisal of travellers' narratives as complex accounts of countries, neither complicit in imperial dominion nor dismissive of indigenous agency, as has been shown of eighteenth-century South Africa (Guelke and Guelke 2004) and Vancouver Island (Clayton 2000). Others have utilised the travel account as an interpretive lens through which to understand questions of landscape, race and gendered identity in historical context (Guelke and Morin 2001; Morin 1999).

The prevalence of such work not only confirms the widespread inter-disciplinary interest in travel narratives. It also, and simultaneously, has had the effect of blurring the boundaries between disciplines: the study of narratives of travel may thus be a distinctively trans-disciplinary concern. Yet, while this may be so, we would argue that these endeavours, rich and important as they are, are too commonly distinguished by an uncritical engagement with the making of the texts themselves.

It is our contention that in the study of travel narratives too little consideration is given to the epistolary and inscriptive practices and, particularly, to the author–publisher relationships that lie within and behind printed works. It is our further contention that too little attention has been paid to the epistemological relationships that connect the writer's narrative – and how, where and why the work was undertaken – to their experiences in the field, and to the published version of the work, the latter being used, too readily, as a finished printed resource without reference to the conditions of its making. Journal accounts of voyages of oceanic navigation in the late eighteenth century, for example, had to make a further 'voyage into print' (Bourguet 1997) to become published narratives, yet many often did so only after the mediation of others and then in abridged or amended form. Publishers acting as editors could and did alter their authors' works in order to serve different demands: to ensure that the printed rendition of Arctic exploration give greater weight to the arduousness of the task even though the explorer-author had played down such matters (MacLaren 1994); or, of Pacific travel accounts, by altering the content of different editions to represent indigenous populations in specific ways (MacLaren 2003); or meeting perceptions of audience expectations by

amending the author's intentions as Blackwood did of John Hanning Speke (Finkelstein 2002).

This paper is concerned with these questions of epistolarity, epistemology and editing that permeate the production of narratives of travel and exploration. We expose to scrutiny the processes of authorship, textual redaction and publishers' editorial accountability that lie within such books' making. Our particular concern is in exploring the nature of geography's authorship when the publisher was, simultaneously, editor, author and publisher of books of travel and exploration. Our broader concern in examining what others have seen as the many 'instabilities of print' (McKitterick 2003, 217–30) is to deepen and extend connections between geography, book history and the history of science.

In illustrating these claims, we examine a range of travel narratives published by the publisher John Murray.¹ The production by Murray of narratives of travel and exploration was perhaps the firm's 'greatest contribution to the advancement of knowledge and of human understanding of the world' (Carpenter 2008, 124): the firm published over 250 such books between 1778 (the date of the firm's founding) and the mid nineteenth-century. In addition to a selection of published books, we examine the manuscript correspondence between publisher and authors to disclose the relationships between author and editor, and between editors and readers employed by the firm to judge submitted or intended works. From this, we reveal not just how and where authors undertook their written work – in the field, on board ship, on the move, at home, or a combination of these – but also how and why Murray as editor-publisher – what we here term the 'mediator' – amended the texts as material and authorial objects.

Geography, book history and materialist hermeneutics

Our emphasis on authorship and editing, which, with other processes, helped constitute books of travel and exploration as assemblages of practice, is consistent with work in the history of science and in book history that has centred on the making of science and the mobility of print as forms of communicative action (Johns 1998b; Lenoir 1998; Pickering 1992; Secord 2000 2004; Topham 2000). This is in part because concerns with materiality in book history enjoy close connections with work in

the history of science. Practitioners in both fields have utilised the same theoretical approaches and addressed the ways by which local circumstances 'were made into general, or public, knowledge through print' (Johns 1998b, 189). In part, too, this conjoint interest is rooted in attention to the processes making up the idea of 'knowledge in transit' (Secord 2004). Books are not simply the *via media* of scientific – and geographical – knowledge. They are one important means by which that knowledge exists at all:

In their material form media do not provide mere 'representatives' of an object described by theory, they create the space within which the scientific object exists in a material form. (Lenoir 1998, 12)

Most work in geography that has contributed to this interleaving of book history and the history of science has been concerned either with the production of printed geographical knowledge, or with its reception as a question of review or reading. In the first, the focus has been on writing strategies for different forms of geography (Ogborn 2004; Withers 2004a) and on the epistemological mutability of print and different forms of writing – log keeping, journal entries, accounts books and so on – in the constitution of ideas of commerce and empire (Clayton 2000; Ogborn 2007). Of the second, attention has been drawn to the importance of different interpretive communities reading Darwin's works (Livingstone 2005), and to the interpretation of major works of geography in the early twentieth century (Keighren 2006 2010a 2010b). Scholars from other fields have turned their attention to geographers' books and to their print history – in book historian Rick Sher's discussion of William Guthrie's *New geographical, historical and commercial grammar* (1769) whose later editions, printed in Dublin and in Philadelphia, altered the content and layout of the London-published original to suit Irish and American readers (Sher 2006) – and in historian of science Nicolaas Rupke's work on the national and local reception of the works of Alexander von Humboldt (Rupke 1999 2008).

Robert Mayhew's attention to editing and the paratextual apparatus of books – page layout, use of blank space, positioning of footnotes and so on – has added a new dimension to the geographical interrogation of books as material objects and to their different meanings (Mayhew 2007a 2007b 2010). This builds on his consideration of geogra-

phy's textual production and reception in showing how citationary practices within books' footnotes may be used to constitute notions of readership and epistemic community among geography's authors in the early modern period (Mayhew 2004). Examining the different editions of Varenus's supposedly canonical 1650 text *Geographia generalis* and appraising the later editorial re-casting of this work, Mayhew reveals editing to be a practice productive of different meaning in the 'same' book, and has called for further work on historical approaches to printed evidence around the themes of authorship; audience, dissemination and reception; the production of print; and the historical geography of communication (Mayhew 2007a). Among historians of science, Safier has shown how maps and texts from eighteenth-century Spanish South America, notably the *Histoire des Incas* (1737) were edited, in Paris, to remove or minimise indigenous knowledge claims and prioritise European authorities (Safier 2008).

The collective import of this trans-disciplinary interest and the materialist turn in relation to the study of narratives of travel and exploration has been recognition of books as being more than simply their final printed content, and of their pre-print production and authorial making as more than a straightforward correspondence between the facts of travel and authors' recounting of them. The engagement with *en route* writing – from field notes, to the fuller journal, the draft manuscript, and the published version (MacLaren 1992) – may not be as smooth or as linear a relationship as this suggests. As others recognise,

The published narrative was the end-product of a sequence of stages in the writing of travel, a process through which the explorer in the field was translated into the published author. (Driver 2001, 8)

We subject these claims to empirical scrutiny to show how, for different travel authors associated in one way or another with the Royal Geographical Society (RGS), John Murray altered the content and form of their books – the sequence and structure of their narrative – and so altered their status as authors. Using two extended sets of examples, we address questions about authors' in-the-field redactive actions and Murray's editing as a form of authorial credibility.

John Murray and the production of exploration narrative

Under the editorial control of John Murray II (1778–1843) in particular, the publishing house of John Murray created and managed widespread public interest in travel literature in the late eighteenth and nineteenth century. Because the Murray firm was official publisher to the Admiralty (the commanding authority of the Royal Navy), it undertook the publication in Britain of most narratives of Arctic and African exploration in the first half of the nineteenth century. Several accounts were also mediated by Sir John Barrow, Second Secretary to the Admiralty, a position that required that he scrutinise travel narratives in their pre-print form: Barrow was also a reader for Murray (pre-publication) and a reviewer (post-publication), notably after 1809 in the Murray-published *Quarterly Review* (Fleming 2001).

John Murray edited in part to put the facts of travel into better narrative sequence. This is clear in his emendation of George Back's polar narratives in the 1830s (MacLaren 1994). Back was anxious to get into authorised print an account of what, in effect, had been a failed mission, at least in terms of its end in view (which had been to survey and explore northern Canada). Murray required that what Back called his 'rough Journals, made from each days occurrences'² be put to better order – that is, be re-arranged as to chronology and thematic significance – if they were to be published, so as to attract interest. Lockhart has shown how the West African explorer and Murray author, Hugh Clapperton, undertook his 'in the raw' in-the-field writing in two formats, a log and a journal, altering the second from the record of the first and producing from the result a fair copy that, further amended, was the basis with others' work of the printed account (Lockhart 1999). Murray authors like the Africanist Mungo Park were assisted by others on their return, a situation that makes determining exactly who wrote exactly what about exploration problematic (Withers 2004b 2010). The writing strategies employed in early nineteenth-century South American travel accounts – encouraging 'rough writing' in order to instil geographical immediacy and authorial veracity – and Murray's 'literary marketing' of South America, have also been examined (Keighren and Withers forthcoming).

Murray could be blunt over authors' intended words. Writing in the 1840s to the leading diplomat Sir Charles Macfarlane over his proposed volume on Turkey, at a time when changes to civil government there exposed feudal governance to Western condemnation and alerted British politicians to the precariousness of West–East relations, Murray complimented the author for the 'mass of most curious and most interesting information regarding the Turkish Empire', but proposed drastic changes to the draft:

The incidents of a journey in Turkey have lost their novelty – you will relive [sic] your vessel by throwing them overboard, if not you will incur the risk of being swamped by your cargo. The stringent abridgements which I recommend would amount to *one half* – of the M.S. – but that is a matter of conjecture. I fear such a suggestion may sound disheartening but I make it with the confidence that you will profit both in a literary & pecuniary point of view by the abridgement.³

As Murray managed authors before and after they became such, so he also managed his market. In the 1830s, when the collapse of several British commercial interests in Argentina and Chile caused 'everything connected with South America' to fall into disrepute, Murray refused to countenance further accounts of the region: 'the subject of South America is so utterly devoid of Public interest at the present time' [Murray wrote in 1838 to Woodbine Parish, British diplomat and aspiring author] 'that I do not think that any work relating to it would have a chance of selling sufficiently to defray the expenses of its publication'.⁴ What Murray signalled of Asia Minor in 1847 and South America in 1838, he did in 1841 for accounts of Polar exploration. Writing to his long-time reader, Sir John Barrow, over volumes being proposed by Barrow's son, Murray reckoned the demand for books of travels 'considerably diminished', but he offered Barrow junior a contract, via his father, 'as I do not like to disturb long standing connexions'.⁵ Murray later changed his tune as the concern over Franklin's voyage and disappearance prompted renewed public interest in Polar exploration (Cavell 2008).

John Murray thus actively engaged with his authors' texts in a variety of ways. In economic terms, he kept costs down by keeping initial print runs low, re-printing if demand required (Carpenter 2008). Maps were sometimes re-used or only lightly amended between editions and volume size

reflected Murray's awareness of different sectors within the exploration-book-buying public (Cavell 2008). He was also concerned to amend the narrative sequence in order to make a better book, even to alter the author's words if necessary. This intellectual engagement as editor-publisher makes it important, if difficult, to identify original material forms and an original motivating context in relation to surviving variants and to know clear reasons for the change (see Everest 2000). Murray's role as mediator – considering the recension of texts as both an editorial and an authorial matter (Shillingsburg 1991) – requires that we be circumspect about categories such as 'author': as Mayhew notes,

the author is not a lone figure making a book, but is enmeshed in a whole set of relations with agents, publishers, printers and booksellers to actually get their work into the public domain. (2007a, 27)

In attending to the necessarily collaborative qualities of authorship, our intention is to expose the tension between this creative plurality and the apparent desire for, and creation of, a single authoritative voice. As we show, however, textual authority was often multiple and always negotiated and contested: it resided in, and depended on, assessments of individual credibility as well as the 'corporate authority' that the Admiralty and the Murray firm represented (Buurma 2007, 18).

In-the-field writing and authorial–editorial redaction

Outram has typified the management of geographical data, including its writing and recording, as a binary: between the in-the-field practices of explorers such as Alexander von Humboldt, where writers have the benefit of direct engagement with nature but may be overwhelmed by its empirical richness (as was Humboldt), or the synthesising inscriptive practices of men such as the naturalist Georges Cuvier, whose distance from nature and immobility afforded time for authorial reflection but removed him from the 'real' world (Outram 1999). This dichotomy between 'field work' and 'lab work' – the 'out there' and the 'back here' – is a distinctive feature of research in the geography of science's undertaking (Finnegan 2008; Kohler 2002; Powell 2007).

Assessment of the writing and editing practices of Murray's explorers and authors complicates this

distinction. Hugh Clapperton, the African explorer, kept two separate sets of journals in the field: his 'remark books', a log of daily exploration, were written up in the course of the day; his journal proper, also written in the field, reorganised and supplemented those notes (Lockhart 1999). The facts of Clapperton's illness while travelling that affected his recall of events, delays (often of days) in transcription from the 'remarks book' to the journal and his further amendment of the narrative while back in Britain (even as Barrow was working with a second fair copy to prepare the material for Murray) all mean that it is hard to talk of a definitive authorised version without reference to when and where the writing and its amendment was taking place.

George Featherstonhaugh, a geologist and traveller in the southern United States, made sure that his day-to-day observations – what he called his 'notebook' of 'incidents of the tour' (1844, I, 29) – were transferred into his journal at the end of each week, in order that they be put in narrative form. This delayed organisation of the work mattered less for his remarks on inert geology than it did for his comments on human customs and slavery, which, for their importance, did need to be placed in sequence of occurrence.⁶ The case of a near contemporary was different yet. Sir Charles Fellows' *Journal written during an excursion in Asia Minor* (1839) was highly regarded by contemporaries, including the RGS, given the detail of his description and because parts of his route 'had not before been traversed by any European; and is on this account alone that I am induced to lay my Journal before the Public' (Fellows 1839, iii). But his regular writing was a marginal daily activity. 'I am generally on horseback eight hours a day, up at half-past six o'clock and at night write or draw till ten'. Even then, local circumstances demanded particular authorial strategies:

These people are so sociable that no one is ever alone, and I believe that I must occasionally represent myself as an invalid, in order to get time for writing and the other occupations of a traveller. (Fellows 1839, 63, 158)

Fellows later revised his notes – included in an 1852 abridgement of his 1839 work – in a quarantine station in Smyrna: 'To some people the detention of a Lazzaretto is tedious, but after active travel I must say that I always enjoy the repose of arranging my affairs bodily and mental'.⁷

Authorship is here an iterative process of deletion and accretion, privacy and public-ness, mobility and repose, remembering and forgetting. This is also evidence of the importance of good health and good memory in making traveller's narratives, and of the multiple spaces for and practices of inscription in which daily journals of events were altered to become narratives of travel. The discipline of regular writing in the field was closely connected with expectations of observational rigour and bodily discipline, with what we might call authorial regimen. But travel writing was also a matter of editorial redaction elsewhere that diminished authors' engagement with and control over their text.

The noted Ethiopian traveller Mansfield Parkyns began his *Life in Abyssinia* (1853) in a tone of self-effacement:

A book of travels should be either a scientific work or an entertaining one. Mine has, I fear, but little to recommend it in either of these particulars. If it has a merit, it is that I believe most of it to be true. What I have described has been almost entirely what I have myself witnessed, or heard related on the spot. (1853, I, 1)

In continuing, he highlighted the importance of multiple forms of in-the-field writing and of memory:

For geography, I have done but little. The loss of parts of my journal on two different occasions, – on one of which I was deprived of the whole of the observations, maps, &c., that I had made during my stay in Tigre – was a severe blow to this part of my undertaking. A great number of the descriptions were made up from the rough notes I was enabled to retain, and from memory; but these were insufficient to recall the figure part of the business. As this is perhaps the most essential of any, I shall for the future, should I travel, adopt a plan (which I should recommend to other travellers), namely, to make two or three different copies of observations, and retain one always about the person. (1853, I, 5–6)

As recalled fragmentary notes became the basis to printed text, Parkyns left many of the decisions to his publisher, beginning with the title:

I think we might say 'from notes collected during nearly three years residence & travels in that country' – or something of the sort although this is explained in various parts of the work – but you are the best judge – only, if I understand the meaning of personal narrative, I don't quite like it, as I disclaim any intention of exact journaling the events, explaining that I pretend only to

give the reader as true an insight to 'Abyssinian Life' as I can.⁸

He then left the written style to Murray, with two provisos:

As regards alterations I have always said that I yield everything to your superior judgement in these matters. Only two things I would suggest. 1st That I should not like my book to appear 'got up' but to remain as much as possible in my own style bad though it be – & 2nd that in some cases passages & exceptions which might appear superfluous to a good judge or critic might be the very ones which would take most with a large proportion of the less literary public & perhaps it might occasionally be as well to risk a little ill treatment from the critics, with the chance of pleasing the many headed.

In the manners and customs I have put in several extraneous bits, at the advice of literary friends & others who suggested that without some little relief, my book could scarcely hope to be accounted as better than 'an Abyssinian Domestic Cookery'.⁹

Trusting others, geographers included, had earlier proven awkward for Parkyns. Before the Abyssinian travels that provided the basis to his 1853 book, he had addressed the RGS on previous work there (Parkyns 1850).

Before I left England the Geog : Society asked me for a paper I gave them a lot of notes on a tribe of Bedouins which have nothing to do with the present work [his 1853 book]. I of course imagined that they would fish out a few things that might interest them & put them shipshape.

[T]o my astonishment I received the proof sheets of the whole notes with scarcely any alterations & of course in the most unintelligible language possible – Many foreign & idioms literally translated into English &c &c. I corrected these as well as I could but it is altogether a job that I am most heartily ashamed of & which would I doubt not materially injure my reputation if not explained. I have therefore begged Dr Shaw [Secretary to the RGS] to insert an apologetic note at the beginning, & wish if you should happen to see him would explain to him the necessity.¹⁰

Neither Murray the *Journal's* publisher, nor Shaw as RGS Secretary, corrected in public this author's private discomfiture.

Murray thus acted as a more authoritative voice than the author, even as he managed explorers' words to allow them to establish their own authorial status: by virtue of residence in the field

(Parkyns); constant textual recension, in the field and later by others elsewhere (Clapperton); or by establishing an authorial regimen wherein only immobility and secrecy easily allowed the facts of travel to be put to order (Fellows). Murray's role as editor-publisher, sometime 'author', was hybrid, even contradictory. The editorial guidance he offered his authors – his role in shaping their texts – was an often hidden and occult process, notionally invisible to readers who were presented with an illusory single authoritative voice. As one historian of science has characterised this process, the role of the editor-publisher was to 'make "names" for their authors and construct public "identities" for them' (Iliffe 1995, 168). At the same time, the Murray firm, as a consequence of its established reputation in the production of travel and exploration literature, embodied and sought to communicate a sense of authority, credibility and status. In so doing, authority was secured for author and publisher both through processes of more-or-less covert editorial mediation.

Authorship and authorial credibility

Books are not always what their authors wrote or what they claim them to be. In the preface to their *Journal of an Expedition* (1832), the Niger explorers Richard and John Lander noted:

We therefore humbly submit the following narrative to the public, without further apology for any deficiency of style or expression which may be discovered in it. It has at least the merit of a faithful account, for our journals were invariably written on the spot at the close of each day, and in all our observations, to the best of our belief, we adhered religiously to the truth. (1832, I, i)

This declaration about fidelity and adherence to truth – matters of 'epistemological decorum' (Shapin 1994, 193–242) – was a common feature among authors and publishers keen to be documenting things as they really were and to establish honesty and direct observation as criteria of epistemic credibility (for the author) and creditworthiness among the buying and reading public (for the publisher). As we have seen, authorship founded on truth, however arrived at, lent the book and its claims credibility. For Johns, 'The making of credibility should be our subject in analysing the importance and development of the book' (1998b, 194). Quite so, for in closing their preface, the Landers made clear their indebtedness to others:

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We think it necessary, however, to say, that the task of blending our journals into one, as well as constructing the map of our route through the country, has been performed by Lieutenant Becher of the Royal Navy, to whom we offer our sincere thanks, not only for the performance of these laborious services, but also for his friendly aid and valuable suggestions in many other points connected with the production of these volumes. (1832, I, ii)

But all was not what it appeared on the page. Becher, working with Barrow, had taken issue with the Landers' prose because of who they were, rather than what they had written: their lowly social status (one was a former servant, the other a former printer's apprentice) was a source of concern over the truth claims of their narrative. As John Lander put it to John Murray,

I cannot help regretting [sic] exceedingly that because accident has thrown me into a humble sphere of life, my veracity is questioned & my promises treated with indifference & contempt. I am very much afraid Mr Becher has not behaved to me with the candour & Sincerity of a Gentleman.¹¹

Where Murray's editorial staff redacted Back's words, the Landers' twin field-based accounts were put to order, later and elsewhere, by a third 'author' who, in concert with others, supplemented the brothers' narrative with additional map work and, in helping give their printed narrative an authoritative 'voice', transformed both word and author.

The status 'author' and the associations between authorship and authoritativeness was thus something that concerned Murray's writers and Murray as publisher-editor. Where the Landers and Parkyns chose self-effacement, others adopted self-promotion. The brothers Henry and Frederick Beechey had conducted a land-based survey of the northern coast of Africa in 1821–22, the results of which were published by Murray in 1828 as *Proceedings of the expedition to explore the northern coast of Africa* (Beechey 1828). In preparing the work for publication, Frederick Beechey wrote to Murray to ensure that the title page give due recognition to their scientific status:

My brother & myself also wish you to say By authority the narrative &C and will you be good enough to place 'FRS & Member of the Astronomical Society' after my name – and let it succeed to my brothers.¹²

Murray published the work only under Frederick Beechey's name, despite the fact that this was a

joint exercise in authorship. Frederick later chastised Murray over the

distinction given to me as author of the Account of an Expedition ... by the mention of my name singly, to which I am not entitled, my Brother, Mr Henry Beechey, having had at least an equal share of the labour of its compilation. ... It would afford me pleasure if this note could be made the means of removing from the public mind the imprecision which the mention of my name singly, in the before alluded to publication, may have created.¹³

Other travellers sought credibility in their authorship by association with scientific status. On the author's instruction, the title page to Sir John Davis' work on China, *The Chinese* (Davis 1857), was amended just in time for publication:

As I was a few days ago elected a fellow of the Royal Society, you may in the title page of my Book designate me an F.R.S. ... I had rather [you] leave out 'the East Indian Company's Civil Service'.¹⁴

By contrast, Mountstuart Elphinstone, author of a well-received account on Afghanistan (Elphinstone 1815), was insistent that his publicised erroneous status as an FRS, which Murray had placed in an advertisement to his book, be corrected: 'Trifling as the mistake is, it will be as well to correct it in any future notice'.¹⁵ The scriptural geographer Josias Leslie Porter was explicit in his search for status through authorship. Following publication of his successful *Five years in Damascus* (Porter 1855), Porter informed Murray and involved him in his plans:

I think it might be well for me to draw up a short memoir of the map for the Royal Geog. Society. It would tend to bring my researches more into notice; and besides, as I am anxious to become a fellow of that Society, it would serve as a kind of introduction. I would feel obliged if you would kindly inform me what steps I ought to take to become a Fellow, or what qualifications are requisite.¹⁶

Authorship was also commonly represented as a collaborative process, with the stated author on the title page at pains to stress that the narrative owed greatly to others' endeavours, as well as the writer's own. This could work in one of several ways. One was acknowledgement in print of the material agency of others in the field on whom the writer was reliant: in the form of direct observation, reliable local witnesses and, importantly, verbal testimony from informants that corroborated the writer's evidence. Knowing through being told by

authoritative sources was thus vital to the creation of the author as authority (Fricker 2004; Lipton 1998; Shapin 1994). But such testimony also presented epistemological problems precisely because it was 'native' in origin: questions of trust, reliability and authority were, as John Lander realised, ineluctably social and moral questions (Barnett 1998). Because this was so, another way in which authorship was established was through the publisher's engagement with the textual content and its narrative order.

On its publication, the three-volume work *Travels into Bokhara* (1834a) by Lt Alexander Burnes was praised as a 'manly, graphic, eloquent & highly interesting *viva voce* narrative'.¹⁷ Burnes had undertaken the work in an official capacity and from personal motives: as a contemporary noted 'It is the journal of an Officer who has trodden those unfrequented regions partly as an accredited Agent of his Government and partly in a love of travel and research'.¹⁸ Burnes had prepared the ground for the book of his travels by addressing the RGS in March 1834 (Burnes 1834b). He received the Society's Gold Medal for his work later that year. The Murray firm published the Society's *Journal* and so had prior notice of the importance of Burnes's work.

But what circulated in public as Burnes's work was neither his alone, nor written in the sequence of the three published volumes. Writing to Murray in January 1834 that he 'will spare neither pains nor labour to make the publication worthy of notice',¹⁹ Burnes claimed he began by preparing and amending his field notes on the first volume of the work, the voyage on the Indus. In fact, he had already sent the Indus portion of his narrative to Mountstuart Elphinstone, author of a work on the region (Elphinstone 1815) with the instructions that he then 'send it to Captain Maconochie after he has made his critique and Captain M. will shew it to you'.²⁰ Alexander Maconochie, a founder member of the Royal Geographical Society in 1830, was the first professor in geography at University College, London, from 1833 to 1836. As others read his Indus work, Burnes sent his manuscript on Bokhara to Murray:

as they do not interfere in any way with the Bokhara journey I do not imagine that any delay need take place in commencing on the printing of that Narrative which forms the 2nd volume – or in proceeding with Book 1st – the general and Geographical matter – which forms the first part of the 3d volume.²¹

But as a result of Maconochie's and Elphinstone's reading of the draft, Burnes revised his plans for the content and the order of the volumes:

I now forward you the last portion of my M. S. the Indus voyage – After mature reflection I have come to the conclusion that it must form the 3rd volume of the work & not the first which I can explain in the preface – I am led to this opinion by Mr Elphinstone's critique & I am confirmed in it by the circumstances of the one work being perfectly distinct from the other, tho' both are parts of the whole – The Bokhara travels are by far the most interesting likewise.²²

In doing so, Burnes altered in publication what had been the chronological sequence of his travels and so underplayed the initial objective, charting the course of the Indus. This fact was commented upon, and in turn amended, by reviewers. In the *Quarterly Review*, the reviewer commented upon the 'awkwardness to the reader' that followed from the author's 'inverting the chronological order of the travels performed'.

The reason assigned is, 'that its interest is, perhaps, greater than that of the Voyage;' we are by no means sure of that: both are sufficiently interesting, and there are many reasons why the Narrative should have proceeded in the order of time, as we intend our notice of it shall do.²³

And in the *Analyst* in February 1835, the reviewer commented likewise:

In defiance, as it were, of all system whatever, our author has chosen to invert the chronological order of his proceedings, and has given to his more recent journey into Bokhara priority over his voyage up the Indus. . . .

In the short notice which follows, we shall treat of the two expeditions in the order in which they were undertaken, in preference to that in which our traveller has chosen to describe them, and we recommend his readers to follow the same plan.²⁴

Even, then, as the book circulated in public as a printed object, its meaning and structure was not 'fixed': reviewers re-ordered for readers what authors had prepared and publishers had amended, as narrative sequences in different print order from their undertaking in the field.

Burnes' book was hugely successful, selling 900 copies in one day. A second edition followed in 1835, to which Burnes 'added a little and I believe materially improved the arrangement'.²⁵ He did so, with Murray's involvement, in part by reposition-

ing the footnotes and adjusting the margins of the book: 'I like the size [in the manuscript this word is scored through and the word 'appearance' is written above] also which when bound up will make the work of the size of Lyell's *Geology* I imagine'.²⁶ If his authorial status was, thus, in part secured by association with a leading earth scientist, and involved the agency of his publisher modifying the paratextual form of the volume, it was also made by management of his re-presentation as author in the book's frontispiece portrait:

I would like however if you could make some alteration in my visage in the 'Costume of Bokhara' [the title given to the portrait of the author in the 1834 edition] for it is said to be so rich and cunning that I shall be handed down to posterity as a real Tartar!²⁷

Murray did not amend the illustration for the second edition, but an amended title 'Sir Alexander Burnes in the costume of Bokhara' (Burnes was knighted in 1838) was used of the frontispiece portrait to Burnes' 1842 book, *Cabool: being a personal narrative of a journey to, and residence in that city, in the years 1836, 7, and 8* (Burnes 1842). Both publisher and author stood to gain by such enhanced authority.

These examples show how Murray managed the content and the order of his authors' words – and, even, one author's appearance – as the texts moved from manuscript to print. For some, Murray the editor-publisher provided a crucial means by which authors sought status through and beyond their texts: as an FRS (Davis); by not being an FRS (Elphinstone); by having their words recast because of their ascribed social status (the Landers). But as the example of Burnes' *Travels into Bokhara* shows, Murray could not necessarily control how reviewers would see the text in relation to the actual chronology and geography of travel and, thus, how such re-ordered narratives were read.

Conclusion: exploring narratives of travel

In closing his discussion of the path from exploration to publication of George Back's polar narrative, MacLaren notes that

It is in the nature of this line of enquiry . . . that the findings of one book or of one explorer are not necessarily pertinent to any other case.

He further remarks,

Nor should the availability of publishers' correspondence with authors necessarily serve to undermine the status of the published text itself. (1994, 51–2)

We concur and offer additional remarks about narratives' travel into print.

The evidence here cited with reference to examples from Murray-published books between 1815 and 1857 suggests that the authorial redaction of narratives of travel and exploration by the publisher acting as editor as well as by authors was commonplace. What MacLaren has shown for the polar narratives of George Back in the 1830s and Lockhart of Clapperton in 1820s West Africa was happening for the Far East, the Near East and central Asia. It was so because, for Murray, the facts to be recounted about travel required to be put in an order – in the field or elsewhere, sometimes both – to ensure that recorded events became a narrative. Crucially, for the publisher-editor the author's own position – relative to the source material, to readers and to the category 'author' – had to be clearly established. Our evidence has shown that the relationship between author and editor-publisher was complicated. Authors had their texts amended by others; authors sought authoritativeness in their truth claims by reference to social status, by association with other writers, or through prior dissemination of related work; later editions amended earlier facts. Editor-publishers and authors re-wrote the actual chronology and geography of the travel in order to make the narrative of it read better, whether as more rigorous or disciplined science, or adventuresome travel and thus to satisfy the perceived requirements and preferences of the reading public. In review, meanings were re-cast yet further by the material order in which narratives were presented.

At one level, these findings are neither novel nor surprising: all published authors will be cognisant of the issues involved in the shift of their words from rough notes written on the spot to printed publication. At another level, however, these findings are significant. They suggest the need to understand, here for British-published narratives of travel and exploration in the first half of the nineteenth-century, that the printed book may not recount things as or when they happened, and that it was not alone the work of the author as practitioner. The category 'author' was arrived at in a number of ways. But rather than see 'author' and 'editor-publisher' as categories, however fluid, we

have pointed to the importance of the relationship between such notions in understanding how travellers' (and others') words made the move into print. Editing is itself 'an effort of scholarship' (Everest 2000, 199), and thus of authorship. Further, where the notion of the 'go-between' has been seen largely to refer to the indigenous interlocutor between native agents and transient explorers (Schaffer *et al.* 2009), that term, like that of mediator, has relevance in describing how men like John Murray worked between his authors and their accounts, within their words and worlds.

This work thus highlights how questions to do with the mediation of authors' experiences and words by editor-publishers and, thus, the material making of books can be thrown open to critical scrutiny. This study has mainly examined the work of men whose geographical enquiries, either before or after publication in book form, found an audience in the RGS or whose exploration was officially sanctioned in one way or another. Study of the John Murray Archive and of correspondence between author and publisher not only suggests that the processes of authorship and editorial redaction were commonplace for all sorts of travellers' accounts – irrespective of the author's gender, social status or intellectual affiliation – but also that Murray managed his authors even before they achieved that status. We should not assume that Murray's editorial role was defined solely by changes made to the textual content of author's manuscripts. Editorial mediation has to do, more broadly, with the decisions taken about likely audience interest, the appropriateness of illustrations, the size and detail of maps, the format and price of the book, about print-runs and distribution – all factors that contributed to 'defining' the author, shaping a text's impact, the meaning and authority it conveyed, and the audience it was likely to reach.

The wider implications of such a materialist approach to the making of books of travel and exploration are several-fold. We are not suggesting that travel accounts cease to be read for what they say. We are calling for attention, through study of publishers' archives, to the processes of authoring and editing 'behind' printed books themselves and other sources, to the precariousness in historical context of the category 'geographical author' and to the constitutive and relational processes of authoring and editing. Others have begun to do so

for travellers' notebooks (Bourguet 2010). Attention hitherto given to the facts of what is written as printed account might now turn to the variances between stages of a narrative's production, and to how the author, in concert with others, worked to order their words in order to claim authoritativeness in the eyes of given audiences. If this is to place 'a sharp focus' on to the writer/author and to the processes of authoring (MacLaren 1992, 40), it is also to call for more work and a sharp focus on the editor and on editing. As Mayhew notes,

To the extent that editing has been studied at all as a set of print processes intended and managed by an individual, it has largely been as part of a more traditional conception of bibliography and has concerned practical problems in the editing of scientific and geographical texts for modern standard editions. (2010, 159–60)

This paper has shown that editing was something that geographical authors did and that the processes of geographical authoring and of authorising was something publishers acting as editors did, sometimes in association with writers, on occasion not. That this is so has implications not least, as have been recognised, for deepening the connections between 'the rubrics of geography and the history of the book':

First, an attentiveness to the findings of the historians of the book can inflect and deepen our narratives of the history of geography as a discipline. Secondly, editing points to substantive ways in which spaces of book production, reception and dissemination come to exhibit geographical difference. (Mayhew 2010, 185).

A focus on the materiality of books as consequent on the outcome of relational processes between 'author', 'editor' and others, and on the processes by which authors assured themselves and their readers of their status can help us understand the complexity of the move of travel into print and of authors' and books' relationships to the worlds they purport to reveal.

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Notes

- 1 This paper is based on results from an AHRC-funded project 'Correspondence: exploration and travel from manuscript to print, 1768–1848' [AHRC ref: AH/F009364/1]. This involved ourselves in the Institute of Geography, Dr Bill Bell of the Centre for the History of the Book, University of Edinburgh, and Mr David McClay, Curator, John Murray Archive, National Library of Scotland.
- 2 National Library of Scotland [hereafter NLS], MS 40033, fol 23 G Back to J Murray 29 September 1837.
- 3 NLS, MS 41912, fol 96, J Murray to C Macfarlane 12 October 1847.
- 4 NLS, MS 41910, fol 1, J Murray to W Parish 12 July 1838.
- 5 NLS, MS 41911, fol 57, J Murray to J Barrow 5 January 1841.
- 6 As Featherstonhaugh noted in writing to Murray, the combination of the geology and the 'view of the manners and customs' was less important than the fact that they were of 'a part of America which has not been described'. That fact was, in turn, less important than his avowed condemnation of slavery by the Americans: 'the only cure for that queer race [white slavery-owning Americans] is to shame them out of the absurd character they are making for themselves'. NLS, MS 40395, G Featherstonhaugh to J Murray 3 February 1844.
- 7 NLS, MS 40395, C Fellows to J Murray 5 June 1840.
- 8 NLS, MS 40917, M Parkyns to J Murray 27 May 1853.
- 9 NLS, MS 40917, M Parkyns to J Murray 24 July 1853.
- 10 NLS, MS 40917, M Parkyns to J Murray [no date].
- 11 NLS, MS 40668, J Lander to J Murray 7 August 1831.
- 12 NLS, MS 40668, F Beechey to J Murray 18 February 1825.
- 13 NLS, MS 40668, F Beechey to J Murray 20 October 1829.
- 14 NLS, MS 40319, J Davis to J Murray 5 August 1834.
- 15 NLS, MS 40378, M Elphinstone to J Murray 25 June 1840.
- 16 NLS, MS 40969, J L Porter to J Murray 1 October 1853. On Porter's work as a scriptural geographer, see Aiken (2010).
- 17 This quote, taken from the December 1834 issue of the *Literary Gazette*, appears also in NLS, MS 42050, fol 2.
- 18 NLS, MS 42050, fol 1.
- 19 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 25 January 1834.
- 20 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 9 January 1834.
- 21 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 25 January 1834.
- 22 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 5 February 1834.

- 23 [Anon.], [Review of A Burnes, *Travels into Bokhara* (1834)], *Quarterly Review* 52 (November 1834), 369–70.
 - 24 [Anon.], [Review of A Burnes, *Travels into Bokhara* (1834)], *Analyst: A quarterly journal of science, literature, natural history and the fine arts* 2 (February 1835), 49.
 - 25 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 7 November 1834.
 - 26 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 28 December 1834. Burnes's reference here is to work by the geologist Charles Lyell, *Principles of Geology*, published by Murray in three volumes between 1830 and 1833.
 - 27 NLS, MS 42048, A Burnes to J Murray 28 December 1834.
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